



PETE KIEHART/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Workers erect fencing around Dupont Circle Park after the National Park Service ordered it closed until Sunday evening.

Feds fence off Dupont Circle Park

BY MARISSA J. LANG, RACHEL WEINER AND JOE HEIM

For the first time, the park at the heart of the District’s historic LGBTQ neighborhood will be closed to the public for all of Pride weekend as the nation’s capital continues to host one of the largest Pride Month observances in the world.

The National Park Service ordered Dupont Circle Park closed from 5 a.m. Friday until 6 p.m. Sunday, after requests from the U.S. Park Police and D.C. Police Chief Pamela A. Smith. Both agencies pointed to several incidents during the past few years that they said threatened public safety and what the NPS called

Despite outcry, a center of LGBTQ life is shut for Pride weekend

the “natural and cultural resources” in the park.

Fencing off the park completely and barring public entry, a Park Police commander wrote in a memo this week, would “combat criminal behavior.”

The closure comes after days of uncertainty among community members and elected officials who for almost a week have pressed the mayor’s office, D.C. police and other leaders for answers — and a remedy — as they

worked to determine whether the public would have access to the park during the biggest weekend of WorldPride.

Mayor Muriel E. Bowser (D) told reporters Friday that she learned of her chief’s request only this week, even though it was made in April.

Several D.C. Council members and neighborhood commissioners who represent residents in the Dupont Circle area thought for much of the week that the decision could, and would, be reversed.

Bowser, who declined for days to answer questions about the park closure, addressed it for the first time in a public-radio appearance Friday afternoon. She called the action an “unfor-

unate error” and said she would “continue to try to lean on” the National Park Service “for a different decision.”

“But we do have to be prepared for a no,” she added, noting that police have “a lot of events to be responsible for” this weekend and that “unfortunately, the public safety issue rose to the top over the public celebration.”

Outside the radio station, she told reporters that the chief had acknowledged it was a mistake. “She didn’t fully appreciate the significance of the Circle during this time,” Bowser said.

SEE DUPONT ON A16

Why they rally: WorldPride-goers have many reasons to be here. B1

Abrego García is returned to U.S. to face charges

DEPORTEE ACCUSED OF HUMAN SMUGGLING

U.S. argued Md. resident couldn’t be brought back

BY MARIA SACCHETTI, PERRY STEIN AND JEREMY ROEBUCK

The wrongly deported Salvadoran man whose removal to a notorious gang prison ignited a standoff between the Trump administration and federal courts has been returned to the United States and charged with human smuggling, Attorney General Pam Bondi said Friday.

The charges against Kilmar Abrego García — one of three men deported by the Trump administration whom courts have ordered returned to the U.S. — mean he

will face prosecution in U.S. courts. If convicted, Bondi said, the government would again seek to deport him to El Salvador after he completes his sentence.

The Supreme Court ordered Trump officials weeks ago to facilitate Abrego García’s return from El Salvador, where Justice Department lawyers admitted he’d been sent in violation of an immigration judge’s order forbidding it. Trump, his Cabinet members and their representatives in court had insisted they could not bring him back because Abrego García was in Salvadoran custody.

SEE ABREGO GARCIA ON A5

Trump-Musk quarrel reopens a GOP fault line

Fiscal hawks also disdain the price of signature tax bill, complicating its path

BY LIZ GOODWIN, PATRICK SVITEK, JEFF STEIN AND MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR

The implosion of billionaire Elon Musk’s relationship with President Donald Trump has not just turned into a political headache for congressional Republicans — it has also frustrated their efforts to deliver on the president’s agenda.

The fight between the Republican Party’s two most important figures, triggered by Musk’s open

disdain for the price tag of Trump’s signature legislation, reopened a fault line in the GOP between the party’s fiscal hawks and those who have embraced Trump’s populist promises not to touch Medicare or Social Security.

“I don’t argue with him on how to build rockets,” House Speaker Mike Johnson (R-Louisiana) said Friday of Musk, on CNBC. “And I wish he wouldn’t argue with me on how to craft legislation and pass it.”

Neither Trump nor Musk publicly worked to de-escalate tensions Friday as many Republicans

SEE TRUMP ON A4

Russia: Officials delight in rift, offer mediation and asylum. A5

Butterworth’s: At the MAGA hangout, cheers to the split. C1

Scramble is on after too many people fired by DOGE

This article is by Hannah Natanson, Adam Taylor, Meryl Kornfield, Rachel Siegel and Scott Dance

Early this spring, the Food and Drug Administration fired nearly 50 workers in the Office of Regulatory Policy — only to turn around and order them back to the office with one day’s notice.

After dismissing thousands of probationary employees for fabricated “performance” issues, the IRS reversed course and told them to show up to work in late May.

And some staff at the U.S. Agency for International Development, dismantled in the first days of the Trump administration by a gleeful Elon Musk and his cost-cutting team at the U.S. DOGE Service, checked their inboxes this month to find an unexpected offer: Would you consider returning — to work for the State Department?

Across the government, the Trump administration is scrambling to rehire many federal employees dismissed under DOGE’s staff-slashing initiatives after wiping out entire offices, in some cases imperiling key services such as weather forecasting and the

SEE DOGE ON A12

Social Security: High court lets DOGE access data on millions. A5



SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

A return to Syria — and difficult memories

A damaged photo of Bashar al-Assad sits outside one of his ousted regime’s torture prisons. Washington Post photographer Salwan Georges visited Syria to see how it had changed since he was a young refugee there, and to find his father’s poem on a cell wall. **Story, A8-9**

City leaders ask if Norton remains D.C.’s ‘warrior’

Some on council fear that delegate, at 87, has lost fitness to fight for District

BY MEAGAN FLYNN, MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR AND PAUL KANE

Several elected officials and allies of Eleanor Holmes Norton (D), D.C.’s longtime nonvoting delegate in the House, are publicly raising questions about whether the deeply respected civil rights icon, known as D.C.’s “warrior on the Hill,” is the effective and vigorous leader the city needs as it faces escalating threats to its home rule.

Norton recently told Washingtonian magazine that she plans to seek reelection despite questions about her fitness. Four D.C. Council members told The Washington Post they are concerned about Norton — who turns 88 next week and is the oldest member of the House — seeking a 19th term, and three said or suggested it is time for the city’s most respected elder to pass the torch.

“I just feel like the past few months, we’ve been behind — we’re reactive,” council member Christina Henderson (I-At Large) said about the District’s strategy on Capitol Hill, acknowledging she has questions about Norton’s



MARVIN JOSEPH/THE WASHINGTON POST

Eleanor Holmes Norton (D) has said she will seek a 19th term as D.C.’s delegate to Congress.

level of engagement.

Donna Brazile, a longtime Democratic strategist and one of Norton’s closest confidants, said in an interview that the delegate is aware of the concerns and is now mulling whether to run for reelection next year.

“It’s time to turn things over. You’ve done it all,” Brazile said of her friend.

“To anyone questioning my ability to serve effectively, I have one simple response: My record speaks for itself,” Norton said in a statement to The Post.

Given Norton’s stature, many in

SEE NORTON ON A2

IN THE NEWS

Scared to go home President Donald Trump’s travel ban has international students afraid to travel abroad, and those who left the U.S. for summer break are scrambling back. A6

Signalgate probe The Pentagon watchdog is examining whether it was Pete Hegseth or an aide who divulged attack plans. A6

THE NATION More than 4 in 10 Republicans worry Medicaid cuts could hurt their communities. A3

Bruce Springsteen’s Republican fans stick with him as he spars with the president. A3

THE WORLD In India, misinformation flooded news outlets during the recent Pakistan conflict. A7

Moscow launched a major air assault across Ukraine in retaliation for Kyiv’s strikes. A10

THE ECONOMY An economic slowdown could spur businesses to turn to artificial intelligence, increasing job worries. A11

Employers added 139,000 jobs in May, beating expectations and showing labor market resiliency amid economic uncertainty. A16

THE REGION The former D.C. police officer convicted of leaking information to the Proud Boys was sentenced to 18 months. B1

Thousands of veterans rallied at the National Mall to protest proposed Veterans Affairs cuts and a dramatic overhaul of the government. B1

STYLE Graphic testimony was the common thread throughout the week at the sex-trafficking trial of rap mogul Sean “Diddy” Combs. C1

SPORTS Can we learn something about the Commanders from one post-practice workout? D1

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The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54240

